September of 1951. Until that point, India's administrative control in Ladakh and Arunachal Pradesh (then NEFA) had been poor. In February 1951, India extended its administration to Tawang and began sending occasional patrols to Aksai Chin from Ladakh. [86]

When Panikkar departed China in June 1952, he remained confident that Beijing would respect India's trade and cultural interests in Tibet. But China's Premier Zhou Enlai directly contradicted it just a month later. [87] During discussions in the early 1950s between India and China, Beijing—led by Zhou—initially did not seem keen to discuss the boundary issue. This move was interpreted in some quarters in India as a sign of China's acquiescence to India's position. At the advice of Panikkar, Nehru did not raise the boundary issue with Zhou, believing that it would lead to China pursuing a stronger claim south of the McMahon Line. Instead, India opted for ambiguity, believing that it was buying time to reinforce its own positions on the ground. Indian maps in 1954 showed Aksai Chin as Indian territory.

The same year, amid echoes of '*Hindi-Chini bhai-bhai* [India and China are brothers]', the two countries signed a series of agreements. While covering trade and religious pilgrimages, and designated routes for passage, the agreements clearly mentioned the 'Tibet Region of the People's Republic of China'. The two premiers also underscored non-aggression and peaceful co-existence, among the five principles that became known as Panchsheel. Additionally, India handed over postal, telegraph, and telephone services in Tibet to China. [88] While the agreements of 1954 were designed to mitigate suspicion between the two countries, some in India remained sceptical, and suggested that check posts be established at key locations such as Demchok to prevent Chinese infiltration. A few Indian officials believed that China had conceded nothing, while India had given up significant leverage. [89] Sure enough, Indian political or trade missions in Tibet—at Lhasa, Gyantse, Yadong, and Gartok—became more restricted and isolated. Additionally, differences soon emerged over Barahoti in the middle sector. China began to publish maps that showed large tracts of Indian territory to be parts of China. [90]